

Day 1 — Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam: One Family

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students will recite the phrase *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* with its meaning, name its source (Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71–73), and give one concrete example of “treating something non-human as family” that they have actually seen.

Materials

- Whiteboard with the phrase pre-written in Devanāgarī and IAST
- Printed handout: the half-verse with translation (one per pair)
- Sticky notes (10 per student)
- A large sheet of chart paper labelled “Family” in the centre

Vocabulary introduced today

- *vasudhā* (IAST: *vasudhā*; lit. “the wealth-holder, the earth”) — the Earth as the bearer of all things.
- *eva* (IAST: *eva*) — “indeed, itself.”
- *kuṭumba* (IAST: *kuṭumba*; lit. “household, family”) — a family unit, including extended members.
- *kam* — neuter ending; *kuṭumbakam* = “a family” (the same word with diminutive / endearing tone).
- Combined: *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* — “the Earth herself is one family.”

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- On the chart paper labelled “Family,” ask each student to write *one* name on a sticky note — someone they consider family — and stick it on the chart.
- After a minute, ask: “*How many of these are humans? Anyone include a pet? A grandparent’s tree? A river? A god? A toy?*”
- Read 5–6 of the notes aloud without judgement. Most will be human. That’s the data we start with.

Core (20 min)

1. **Write the phrase on the board** in Devanāgarī, then IAST, then word-by-word translation:

वसुधैव कुटुम्बकम् — *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* — “the Earth itself is one family.”

2. **The fuller verse.** Read the whole half-verse from the handout:

ayaṁ nijaḥ paro veti gaṇanā laghu-cetasām / udāra-caritānām tu vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam //

“This is mine, that is theirs — such reckoning is for the small-minded. For those whose conduct is large, the whole earth is one family.” — Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71–73

3. **Notice the structure.** It is a *comparison*. The verse is not saying “the Earth IS literally one family” the way “*water IS H₂O*” is a factual claim. It is saying: *if* you live with a big enough sense of belonging, *then* you treat the Earth as a family. The phrase is an ethic, not a biological description.
4. **Where the phrase has lived.** The same idea appears in the *Pañcatantra* prologue and the *Hitopadeśa* as a quoted line; the Mahā Upaniṣad is the older scriptural source. The phrase has been adopted as the motto of the Indian Parliament’s entrance hall, and India used it as the theme of the G20 presidency in 2023. It travels well.
5. **The historical caveat — don’t oversell.** Plenty of pre-modern Indian rulers cleared forests, drained tanks, and treated land as something to extract from. The phrase is an *ideal* the tradition put forward, not a description of how everyone actually behaved. We’ll keep this honest throughout the module.

Activity (15 min) — The “extended family” chart

- Pairs work together. Each pair gets a fresh sticky-note pad.
- Prompt: “Add 5 non-human things to the family chart — but only ones you have personally encountered. Not ‘the Amazon rainforest’ if you haven’t been there. The neem tree by the gate counts. The mango you ate at lunch counts. The pigeon on your roof counts.”
- After 5 min, each pair sticks their notes on the chart. The chart now has ~70–80 sticky notes, mostly non-human.
- **Discussion (5 min):** “Look at this chart. If treating these as ‘family’ is what the verse asks, what would change about how you behave?” (Sample answers: not littering, not killing things for no reason, knowing names, paying attention.)

Wrap-up (5 min)

- One-sentence exit ticket on a slip of paper: “Write one non-human thing you now consider part of your extended family — and one specific behaviour that will change because of that.”
- Collect the slips. Read 3–4 anonymously at the start of Day 2.

Student-facing content

Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam — “the Earth itself is one family.”

A line from the *Mahā Upaniṣad* (chapter 6, verses 71–73). It is also quoted in the *Pañcatantra* and the *Hitopadeśa*. It became the motto of India’s Parliament hall and the theme of the country’s G20 presidency in 2023.

The full half-verse:

“This is mine, that is theirs — such reckoning is for the small-minded. For those whose conduct is large, the whole earth is one family.”

The verse is an **ethic**, not a biological claim. It tells you what to do, not what is. The next nine days are about what an ecological ethic of “family” actually looks like in practice — in your river, in your trees, in your habits.

Homework

- Add three more sticky-note items to your “extended family” list at home. They must be things you have *personally* encountered today. Bring the list tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Compare *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* with the modern environmental phrase “Earth is our common home” (used by international NGOs and Pope Francis’s 2015 encyclical *Laudato si’*). Are they saying the same thing? What does each emphasise that the other doesn’t?
- **One tier down:** Focus on memorising *vasudhā* (earth) and *kuṭumba* (family). The whole sentence can come on Day 2.

Teacher notes

- Some students will say “but my cat IS family.” Good — affirm that. The verse extends what they already feel. We are not introducing a new feeling; we’re naming one.
- Some students will say “this is just a religious idea — does it count?” Good — name it. Tell them: the verse is religious *in origin*, but the ethic it carries doesn’t require religious agreement. Many cultures have a version of this idea. The lesson is the ethic, not a conversion.
- Don’t say “ancient Indians invented this and the West later borrowed it.” That’s bad history. Multiple cultures arrived at versions of this ethic independently. Indic thought put it in particularly elegant words.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- **Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71–73** — *vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam* verse. Full Sanskrit text per the Adyar Library edition.
- See `sources.md` for editions used.